

QUESTION 1**SECTION: READING_WRITING****CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Idea****DIFFICULTY: EASY**

PROMPT: The following text is adapted from Lena Okafor's 2019 novel *Season of Dust*. Amara is visiting her grandmother's village for the first time in years. The road narrowed as they drove farther from the highway, and the houses grew smaller, their roofs weighted with the rust of decades. When Amara finally stepped out of the car, she recognized nothing -- not the marketplace, not the stone well, not even the mango tree she had once climbed every afternoon. She had expected the village to greet her like an old friend, but it stood distant and unfamiliar, as though her memories belonged to someone else entirely. Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

A: Amara finds that her grandmother's village no longer corresponds to the memories she had carried of it, leaving her feeling like a stranger in a once-familiar place.

B: The visible deterioration of the village's buildings and landmarks is the primary source of Amara's disappointment during her return visit.

C: Amara's return to the village strengthens her emotional connection to her childhood despite the physical changes she observes around her.

D: Amara realizes that her long absence has caused the village to forget her, even though the landscape itself has remained largely unchanged.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Trick: When a passage contrasts what a character expected vs. what they found, the main idea lives in that contrast. 'Expected the village to greet her...but it stood distant' points to memory vs. reality. B narrows to physical decay alone, C reverses the emotional outcome, and D inverts who has changed.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 2

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Idea

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: Tardigrades, microscopic animals sometimes called water bears, are renowned for their ability to survive extreme conditions. They can endure temperatures near absolute zero, withstand intense radiation, and tolerate the vacuum of outer space. Scientists have discovered that tardigrades achieve this resilience by entering a state called cryptobiosis, in which metabolic activity drops to nearly undetectable levels. In this state, the organism essentially suspends all biological processes until conditions improve. Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A: Scientists have recently determined that tardigrades possess unique metabolic pathways that allow them to generate energy even in the most extreme environments.
- B: Tardigrades can survive extreme conditions by entering cryptobiosis, a state in which their metabolic processes drop to nearly undetectable levels.
- C: Although tardigrades are known for their resilience, researchers have found that prolonged exposure to extreme conditions permanently alters their metabolic functions.
- D: The metabolic flexibility of tardigrades allows them to thrive, rather than merely survive, in extreme environments such as outer space.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Trick: Match the mechanism precisely. Cryptobiosis means activity 'drops to nearly undetectable levels' -- a suspension, not an increase or adaptation. A says they 'generate energy' (reversal), C says exposure 'permanently alters' functions (unsupported), and D upgrades 'survive' to 'thrive' (distortion).

END QUESTION

QUESTION 3**SECTION: READING_WRITING****CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Idea****DIFFICULTY: EASY**

PROMPT: A 2022 survey of over 3,000 remote workers found that 68 percent preferred a hybrid schedule -- splitting time between home and office -- over fully remote or fully in-person arrangements. Respondents cited social interaction with colleagues as the primary reason for wanting some office time, while flexibility and reduced commuting were the main advantages of working from home. Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

A: The survey suggests that most remote workers are dissatisfied with both fully remote and fully in-person arrangements because neither option adequately supports their professional development.

B: Fully remote work arrangements are preferred by the majority of workers surveyed because they eliminate commuting and provide greater personal flexibility.

C: A majority of the remote workers surveyed preferred a hybrid schedule, valuing both the social benefits of office time and the flexibility of working from home.

D: The survey found that employers who offer hybrid schedules report higher employee retention rates than those who require full-time office attendance.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Trick: For survey-based passages, the main idea = majority result + stated reasons. A adds 'professional development' (not mentioned), B claims fully remote is preferred (contradicts 68% hybrid figure), and D introduces employer retention data not discussed in the text.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 4**SECTION: READING_WRITING****CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Idea****DIFFICULTY: EASY**

PROMPT: The Rosetta Stone, discovered in 1799, bears the same decree inscribed in three scripts: hieroglyphic, Demotic, and ancient Greek. Because scholars could already read Greek, they used the Greek portion as a key to decipher the other two scripts. The stone thus became the essential tool that unlocked the ancient Egyptian writing system. Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A: The Rosetta Stone was significant primarily because it confirmed that ancient Egyptian and ancient Greek civilizations maintained extensive diplomatic relationships.
- B: Scholars used the Rosetta Stone's Demotic script to verify their existing translations of ancient Greek, refining their understanding of both writing systems.
- C: The Rosetta Stone demonstrated that hieroglyphic, Demotic, and Greek were regional variations of the same underlying language system used across the Mediterranean.
- D: The Rosetta Stone allowed scholars to decode Egyptian scripts because its Greek inscription provided a translation they could already read.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Trick: Follow the cause-and-effect chain. Greek was already readable, so it served as the key to unlock the Egyptian scripts. A invents diplomatic claims, B reverses the direction (Greek was used to read Egyptian, not the other way), and C wrongly merges three separate scripts into one language.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 5

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Idea

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: Coral reefs support roughly one quarter of all marine species, yet they cover less than one percent of the ocean floor. This extraordinary concentration of biodiversity has earned them the nickname 'rainforests of the sea.' However, rising ocean temperatures threaten coral health by causing bleaching, a process in which stressed corals expel the symbiotic algae that provide them with food and color. Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

A: Coral reefs harbor a disproportionately large share of marine biodiversity, but rising ocean temperatures are increasingly threatening their health through bleaching.

B: The symbiotic algae that live within coral reefs are primarily responsible for supporting the roughly one quarter of marine species that depend on reef ecosystems.

C: Coral bleaching is a temporary, naturally occurring process that allows reefs to adapt to changing ocean temperatures by cycling through different species of algae.

D: Scientists have recently discovered that coral reefs are expanding to cover a larger percentage of the ocean floor than previously estimated, offsetting the effects of bleaching.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Trick: A 'however' or 'yet' pivot means the main idea must span both sides. Before the pivot: reefs = biodiversity hotspots. After: bleaching = rising threat. B focuses only on algae (too narrow), C calls bleaching 'temporary' and 'naturally occurring' (not stated), and D claims reefs are expanding (contradicts the text).

END QUESTION

QUESTION 6**SECTION: READING_WRITING****CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Idea****DIFFICULTY: EASY**

PROMPT: The following text is from Tomoko Hara's 2016 short story 'Paper Boats.' Kenji folded the newspaper into a small boat and set it on the stream. He watched it drift toward the stone bridge, wobbling over the current, until it rounded a bend and vanished. Every day he did this, and every day he imagined it reaching the sea. He knew, of course, that it would disintegrate long before then, but the ritual gave him something he could not name -- a quiet permission to hope. Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A: Kenji's daily ritual reveals his growing frustration with the stream's current, which consistently prevents his boats from traveling beyond the stone bridge.
- B: Kenji builds paper boats as a way of processing unresolved grief over a personal loss that the text implies but does not directly identify.
- C: Kenji's awareness that his boats will disintegrate has gradually eroded the meaning he once found in the daily practice of launching them.
- D: Kenji's daily act of launching paper boats provides him with an unnamed sense of hope, even though he knows the boats will never reach the sea.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Trick: In fiction, match the character's explicitly named emotion. The passage says the ritual gave Kenji 'a quiet permission to hope.' A assigns frustration (not stated), B introduces grief (invented), and C says meaning has eroded (opposite of what the text describes).

END QUESTION

QUESTION 7**SECTION: READING_WRITING****CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Idea****DIFFICULTY: EASY**

PROMPT: Psychologist Lev Vygotsky introduced the concept of the 'zone of proximal development,' which describes the gap between what a learner can accomplish independently and what the learner can achieve with guidance from a more skilled person. Effective teaching, Vygotsky argued, operates within this zone -- neither too easy to bore the student nor too difficult to discourage effort. Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

A: Vygotsky's research demonstrated that students who receive no outside guidance consistently outperform those who rely on teacher instruction for learning.

B: According to Vygotsky, effective instruction targets the range between what a learner can do alone and what the learner can achieve with skilled guidance.

C: Vygotsky's zone of proximal development applies exclusively to young children and has limited relevance to adult education or workplace training contexts.

D: Vygotsky argued that assigning tasks well beyond a learner's current ability is the most effective strategy for maximizing intellectual growth.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Trick: Find the boundary phrase. 'Within this zone -- neither too easy...nor too difficult' defines a targeted range. A removes guidance entirely (reversal), C limits the concept to children (unsupported restriction), and D pushes past the upper boundary ('well beyond ability' contradicts 'not too difficult').

END QUESTION

QUESTION 8**SECTION: READING_WRITING****CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Idea****DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM**

PROMPT: Lichen, a symbiotic partnership between fungi and photosynthetic organisms such as algae or cyanobacteria, can colonize some of Earth's most inhospitable surfaces, including bare rock. The photosynthetic partner supplies sugars through photosynthesis, while the fungal partner provides structural support and protection from desiccation. Recent genomic studies have complicated this picture by revealing that many lichens also harbor yeasts and bacteria that contribute to the organism's chemical defenses, suggesting that lichen biology is more complex than the traditional two-partner model implies. Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

A: The structural support provided by the fungal component is the primary reason that lichen can survive on inhospitable surfaces such as bare rock.

B: Recent genomic studies have confirmed that the traditional two-partner model accurately and completely describes lichen biology.

C: New research indicates that lichen partnerships involve additional organisms beyond the traditional fungal-photosynthetic pair, revealing a more complex biology than previously recognized.

D: The chemical defenses of lichen are produced exclusively by the yeasts and bacteria recently discovered in genomic studies, not by the fungal or photosynthetic partners.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Trick: The word 'complicated' signals that something previously thought simple is actually more layered. The passage says lichen biology is 'more complex than the two-partner model implies.' A focuses on only one partner's role (too narrow), B directly contradicts the 'complicated' signal, and D overstates by saying 'exclusively' (the text says yeasts 'contribute,' not that they are the sole source).

END QUESTION

QUESTION 9**SECTION: READING_WRITING****CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Idea****DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM**

PROMPT: During the early twentieth century, the Great Migration saw roughly six million African Americans relocate from the rural South to cities in the North, Midwest, and West. While economic opportunity was a primary motivator, historians emphasize that migrants were also fleeing the daily humiliations and dangers of Jim Crow segregation. The movement profoundly reshaped American culture: northern cities became centers of African American artistic and intellectual life, giving rise to movements such as the Harlem Renaissance. Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A: The Great Migration was driven primarily by economic factors, with social and cultural consequences emerging only after migrants had settled in northern cities.
- B: The Harlem Renaissance was the direct and intended goal of the millions of African Americans who relocated to the North during the Great Migration.
- C: African Americans who participated in the Great Migration universally experienced improved social and economic conditions in the northern cities where they settled.
- D: The Great Migration, motivated by both economic opportunity and the desire to escape segregation, had a lasting cultural impact on American cities.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Trick: Count the causes the passage names. 'Economic opportunity' plus 'fleeing Jim Crow' = two factors, then 'profoundly reshaped American culture' = a result. A downgrades social causes to afterthoughts, B calls the Harlem Renaissance an intended goal (it was an outcome), and C uses 'universally' -- a word the passage never supports.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 10**SECTION: READING_WRITING****CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Idea****DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM**

PROMPT: The following text is from Raul Mendes's 2021 novel *Undertow*. Sofia kept returning to the half-finished painting in her studio, adding a brushstroke here, scraping away a layer there, never satisfied. Her professor had praised the composition, and two classmates had offered to buy it, but she could not see what they saw. To her the canvas revealed only what was missing -- the shade of blue she could imagine but not mix, the texture that existed in her mind but refused to obey her hand. Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A: Sofia is unable to feel satisfied with her painting because she perceives a gap between the work she has produced and the ideal version she envisions.
- B: Sofia's professor and classmates lack the artistic sophistication needed to recognize the flaws that prevent her painting from succeeding.
- C: Sofia's dissatisfaction with her painting stems primarily from her belief that she has not received enough formal instruction in color theory and technique.
- D: Sofia's repeated revisions to the painting demonstrate that she is intentionally delaying its completion in order to avoid external judgment.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Trick: In fiction, locate the internal conflict. Sofia sees 'only what was missing' -- the gap between imagination and execution. Others praise her work, so the conflict is internal, not external. B blames others' taste (passage shows they like it), C invents a training complaint, and D ascribes avoidance of judgment (not supported by the text).

END QUESTION

QUESTION 11**SECTION: READING_WRITING****CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Idea****DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM**

PROMPT: Cephalopods such as octopuses and cuttlefish can alter the color and texture of their skin within milliseconds, a feat accomplished through specialized cells called chromatophores. Each chromatophore contains a sac of pigment controlled by tiny muscles; when the muscles contract, the sac expands and the color becomes visible. Beneath the chromatophores lie iridophores, which reflect light to produce iridescent hues. Working together, these cell layers give cephalopods one of the most sophisticated camouflage systems in the animal kingdom. Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

A: Chromatophores and iridophores serve identical functions in cephalopod skin, each independently producing the full range of colors needed for effective camouflage.

B: Cephalopods achieve rapid, sophisticated camouflage through coordinated layers of specialized cells that control both pigment and reflected light.

C: The speed of cephalopod color changes is primarily attributable to iridophores, which respond to environmental stimuli more quickly than chromatophores do.

D: Scientists remain unable to determine how cephalopod skin cells coordinate their responses quickly enough to produce effective camouflage in natural settings.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Trick: 'Working together' signals a system with distinct parts. Chromatophores handle pigment, iridophores handle light reflection -- the correct answer must credit the coordinated system. A says they are 'identical' (they have different roles), C elevates one component over the other (unsupported ranking), and D claims scientists are unable to determine the mechanism (the passage describes it in detail).

END QUESTION

QUESTION 12**SECTION: READING_WRITING****CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Idea****DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM**

PROMPT: Behavioral economist Priya Nakamura has argued that default options -- the choices that take effect when individuals do not actively make a decision -- exert a disproportionate influence on outcomes. In a study of retirement savings, employees enrolled in plans with automatic contribution defaults saved, on average, 40 percent more than employees who were required to opt in manually. Nakamura contends that such findings challenge the classical economic assumption that individuals always make rational, utility-maximizing choices. Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

A: Nakamura's study found that employees who were required to opt in to retirement plans saved more on average than those enrolled through automatic defaults, confirming classical economic predictions.

B: Default options in retirement savings plans succeed only because employees are unaware that automatic enrollment has occurred, not because defaults genuinely shape decision-making.

C: Nakamura's research demonstrates that default settings have a significant influence on savings behavior, challenging the assumption that people consistently make purely rational economic decisions.

D: Classical economic theory has been entirely discredited by behavioral economists, who have shown that no human decisions are truly rational or utility-maximizing.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Trick: Find the 'challenge' word. Nakamura says her findings 'challenge the classical economic assumption.' The correct answer must include both the finding (defaults shape behavior) and what it challenges (rational-actor theory). A reverses the data, B invents an awareness claim, and D overstates from 'challenge' to 'entirely discredited.'

END QUESTION

QUESTION 13**SECTION: READING_WRITING****CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Idea****DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM**

PROMPT: In 1893, New Zealand became the first self-governing country to grant women the right to vote in national elections, a milestone achieved largely through the efforts of suffragist Kate Sheppard. Sheppard organized a series of petitions that collectively garnered nearly 32,000 signatures -- representing roughly one quarter of the adult female population at the time. While New Zealand's achievement inspired suffrage movements worldwide, women in the country did not gain the right to stand for parliament until 1919. Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A: New Zealand pioneered women's voting rights through organized petition campaigns, though women did not gain the right to hold parliamentary office until decades later.
- B: Kate Sheppard's petition campaigns were initially unsuccessful and required several decades of sustained effort before parliament granted women any political rights.
- C: New Zealand's early adoption of women's suffrage is best attributed to its small population, which made large-scale petition campaigns more practical than in larger nations.
- D: The women's suffrage movement in New Zealand was modeled directly on similar campaigns in Europe and North America that had already succeeded before 1893.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Trick: Spot the time-based qualification. Voting rights came in 1893, but standing for parliament waited until 1919. The correct answer must include the 'achievement + later limitation' structure. B falsely claims the petitions were initially unsuccessful, C invents a population-size argument, and D fabricates a claim about European models preceding New Zealand.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 14**SECTION: READING_WRITING****CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Idea****DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM**

PROMPT: Mycelial networks -- underground webs of fungal threads -- connect the root systems of trees in a forest, enabling nutrient exchange between individuals. Ecologist Jun Tanaka and colleagues found that seedlings growing in the shade of established trees received up to 30 percent of their carbon through these fungal connections. However, Tanaka cautions that the transfer is not purely altruistic: the fungi retain a significant portion of the nutrients as payment for their role as intermediaries. Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A: Mycelial networks are beneficial to seedlings but ultimately harmful to established trees, which lose a significant share of their carbon through fungal extraction without receiving any benefit in return.
- B: Jun Tanaka's research has confirmed that trees deliberately and altruistically direct nutrients to struggling seedlings through fungal networks as a form of cooperative forest behavior.
- C: The primary function of mycelial networks is to distribute water, rather than carbon, among the trees they connect, with nutrient transfer occurring only as a secondary process.
- D: Fungal networks facilitate nutrient sharing among trees in a forest, but the fungi themselves retain a portion of the transferred nutrients for their own benefit.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Trick: A 'however' or 'caution' signal splits the main idea into two parts. Part one: fungi enable nutrient sharing. Part two: the transfer is 'not purely altruistic' because fungi take a cut. A says the network harms established trees (not stated), B calls it 'altruistic' (the passage says the opposite), and C switches the nutrient type from carbon to water (contradicts the text).

END QUESTION

QUESTION 15

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Idea

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: The following text is from Delia Caron's 2018 poem 'Winter Kitchen.' My mother's hands moved like small, certain animals across the flour-dusted counter, folding air into dough as though she were folding the morning itself into bread. I learned her recipes by standing close enough to feel the heat of the oven on my face, and years later, when I open the flour tin, it is her kitchen I step into, not my own. Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A: The speaker uses the act of baking to replicate the mother's recipes with scientific precision, viewing accuracy as the only way to honor the mother's legacy in the kitchen.
- B: Sensory details associated with baking transport the speaker back to the mother's kitchen, creating a powerful link between physical experience and memory.
- C: The speaker's memories of the mother's kitchen have faded significantly over time, and baking has become an increasingly ineffective method of recovering them.
- D: The speaker was never formally taught the mother's recipes and now struggles to recreate them without written instructions.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Trick: Identify the sensory trigger. 'When I open the flour tin, it is her kitchen I step into' -- a physical sensation unlocks a memory. A invents 'scientific precision,' C says memories have faded (the text shows vivid recall), and D introduces struggle with recipes (the speaker learned by standing close, and the connection remains strong).

END QUESTION

QUESTION 16**SECTION: READING_WRITING****CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Idea****DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM**

PROMPT: Urban planner Marcos Espinoza has observed that public parks in low-income neighborhoods frequently receive less maintenance funding than parks in wealthier areas, resulting in crumbling infrastructure and reduced foot traffic. This decline creates a feedback loop: as parks deteriorate, residents use them less, which in turn makes it harder for community advocates to argue for increased funding. Espinoza calls for equitable per-capita allocation of park maintenance budgets to break this cycle. Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A: Espinoza's research demonstrates that residents in low-income neighborhoods voluntarily avoid using public parks regardless of the quality of available facilities.
- B: Funding disparities between parks in wealthy and low-income neighborhoods are the result of deliberate municipal policies intended to redirect resources toward higher-performing districts.
- C: Unequal maintenance funding creates a self-reinforcing cycle of decline in parks serving lower-income communities, and Espinoza proposes equitable per-capita allocation as a remedy.
- D: Espinoza has found that increasing maintenance funding for parks in lower-income neighborhoods would have no measurable effect on foot traffic because the decline has already become irreversible.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Trick: Spot the feedback loop, then check for the proposed solution. The passage describes a cycle (less funding leads to deterioration leads to less use leads to weaker funding arguments) and a remedy (equitable allocation). A blames residents' choices (not supported), B invents deliberate policy intent, and D says the decline is irreversible (contradicts Espinoza's call for a fix).

END QUESTION

QUESTION 17**SECTION: READING_WRITING****CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Idea****DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM**

PROMPT: When glass shatters, the resulting fragments follow surprisingly consistent patterns. Physicist Nadia Volkov demonstrated that the number of fragments produced is proportional to the energy of the impact, and that radial cracks always form before circumferential ones. These predictable fracture mechanics have forensic applications: by analyzing crack patterns, investigators can determine the point and force of impact even when the original object has been removed from the scene. Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A: Glass fracture follows predictable patterns that have practical value in forensic investigations, allowing analysts to reconstruct the circumstances of an impact.
- B: Nadia Volkov's primary contribution to physics was the development of a new type of shatter-resistant glass based on her analysis of fracture mechanics.
- C: Radial and circumferential cracks form simultaneously when glass shatters, making it difficult for investigators to determine which cracks occurred first at a crime scene.
- D: The number of fragments produced when glass breaks varies randomly and cannot be predicted from the energy of the impact, limiting the forensic usefulness of fracture analysis.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Trick: Track from principle to application. The passage moves from describing predictable fracture patterns (science) to noting their 'forensic applications' (practical use). B fabricates a product invention, C says the cracks form simultaneously (passage says radial form first), and D says fragment count is random (passage says it is proportional to impact energy).

END QUESTION

QUESTION 18**SECTION: READING_WRITING****CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Idea****DIFFICULTY: HARD**

PROMPT: The prevailing model of planet formation holds that rocky planets like Earth accrete from collisions among progressively larger bodies called planetesimals. Astrophysicist Yara El-Amin has challenged this model by demonstrating that certain isotopic ratios in meteorites are inconsistent with the gradual accretion hypothesis. El-Amin proposes instead that some terrestrial planets may have formed through the rapid gravitational collapse of dense regions within the protoplanetary disk -- a mechanism previously associated only with gas giant formation. While the hypothesis remains contentious, it has prompted renewed scrutiny of long-accepted assumptions about the early solar system. Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A: El-Amin has established conclusively that rocky planets form through gravitational collapse rather than gradual accretion of planetesimals, overturning decades of established research.
- B: El-Amin's challenge to the standard model of rocky planet formation has generated scientific debate, though her alternative hypothesis of gravitational collapse has not yet been widely accepted.
- C: Analysis of isotopic ratios in meteorites has revealed that the solar system formed more recently than scientists had previously estimated, supporting El-Amin's revised timeline for planetary development.
- D: The mechanisms responsible for the formation of gas giants and rocky planets are now understood to be identical, a conclusion confirmed by El-Amin's meteorite analysis.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Trick: Gauge the certainty language. 'Remains contentious' and 'prompted renewed scrutiny' = tentative and debated, not settled. A uses 'established conclusively' (overstates), C invents a revised age for the solar system (not mentioned), and D says the mechanisms are 'now understood to be identical' (El-Amin says 'some' rocky planets 'may have' formed this way -- hedged, not universal).

END QUESTION

QUESTION 19**SECTION: READING_WRITING****CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Idea****DIFFICULTY: HARD**

PROMPT: Sociologist Elaine Whitfield has critiqued the widespread use of standardized achievement tests as measures of school quality. Whitfield argues that such tests primarily capture variance in students' socioeconomic backgrounds rather than differences in instructional effectiveness. She points to longitudinal data showing that schools serving affluent populations consistently outscore schools in lower-income areas even when the latter employ pedagogical methods rated highly by independent evaluators. Whitfield does not reject assessment entirely; rather, she advocates for value-added models that measure student growth over time, thereby isolating the school's contribution from pre-existing demographic advantages. Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

A: Whitfield argues that schools serving affluent populations achieve higher test scores because they employ more effective teaching methods than schools in lower-income areas, regardless of socioeconomic factors.

B: Whitfield's position is that all forms of student assessment are inherently unreliable and should be replaced by qualitative evaluations conducted by independent observers.

C: Whitfield's longitudinal data demonstrate that independent evaluators are unable to assess pedagogical quality accurately, which undermines confidence in all alternative assessment methods.

D: Whitfield contends that standardized test scores largely reflect socioeconomic advantages rather than instructional quality, and she recommends growth-based assessment models as a more accurate alternative.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Trick: Track what the researcher accepts and what she rejects. Whitfield 'does not reject assessment entirely' -- she opposes standardized tests specifically and proposes value-added models instead. A reverses her argument (she says affluent schools score higher despite, not because of, methods), B overstates to 'all forms' (she advocates an alternative, not elimination), and C misattributes her data (evaluators rated lower-income schools' methods highly, not poorly).

END QUESTION

QUESTION 20**SECTION: READING_WRITING****CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Idea****DIFFICULTY: HARD**

PROMPT: The following text is from Anwar Haddad's 2020 novel *The Cartographer's Silence*. He drew maps not of places he had been but of places he feared would vanish -- marshes that the development authority had marked for draining, forests whose timber had already been auctioned. Each map was an act of preservation, a record of a landscape that might soon exist only on paper. His colleagues called the work sentimental, but he suspected that sentiment was merely the word people used when they wished to dismiss what they lacked the courage to feel. Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A: The cartographer documents landscapes at risk of disappearing, viewing his colleagues' dismissal of his work as a reflection of their own unwillingness to confront difficult emotions.
- B: The cartographer's colleagues share his concern for endangered landscapes but disagree with his unconventional method of documenting them through maps rather than written reports.
- C: The cartographer creates maps of places he has never visited, relying on secondhand accounts because the development authority restricts access to the areas he wishes to document.
- D: The cartographer has been formally commissioned by environmental organizations to create an official historical record of landscapes scheduled for commercial development.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Trick: In fiction, link purpose to response. The cartographer's purpose is preserving vanishing landscapes. His response to criticism redefines 'sentimental' as others' lack of courage to feel. The correct answer must capture both. B falsely claims colleagues share his concern, C invents access restrictions, and D fabricates a formal commission.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 21**SECTION: READING_WRITING****CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Idea****DIFFICULTY: HARD**

PROMPT: Deep-sea hydrothermal vents host ecosystems that rely on chemosynthesis rather than photosynthesis, deriving energy from chemical reactions involving hydrogen sulfide and other compounds. Marine biologist Adaeze Nwankwo has found that microbial communities at these vents exhibit metabolic flexibility, switching between sulfur oxidation and hydrogen oxidation depending on fluid chemistry. Nwankwo suggests that this adaptability may explain why vent ecosystems recover more rapidly than expected after volcanic disturbances that alter the chemical composition of the vent fluids. Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

A: Hydrothermal vent microbes depend exclusively on sulfur oxidation for energy production, which makes them highly vulnerable to volcanic disturbances that reduce sulfur concentrations in vent fluids.

B: Nwankwo's research has demonstrated that photosynthesis plays a larger role in sustaining deep-sea vent ecosystems than scientists had previously recognized.

C: The metabolic flexibility of vent microbes, which allows them to switch between energy sources as fluid chemistry changes, may account for the unexpectedly rapid recovery of vent ecosystems after volcanic disruptions.

D: Hydrothermal vent ecosystems recover slowly from volcanic disturbances because changes in fluid chemistry permanently eliminate the microbial populations that form the base of the food chain.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Trick: Check whether the passage states a confirmed cause or a suggested possibility. Nwankwo 'suggests' that flexibility 'may explain' rapid recovery -- hedged language. A says microbes depend 'exclusively' on sulfur (passage says they switch), B introduces photosynthesis (passage says chemosynthesis), and D says recovery is slow (passage says it is 'more rapidly than expected').

END QUESTION

QUESTION 22**SECTION: READING_WRITING****CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Idea****DIFFICULTY: HARD**

PROMPT: Historian Camille Dubois has re-examined the conventional narrative that the printing press single-handedly democratized knowledge in fifteenth-century Europe. Dubois notes that early printed books were expensive luxury items, largely accessible only to ecclesiastical institutions and wealthy patrons. She argues that the true democratization of print occurred incrementally over two centuries, driven less by the technology itself than by declining paper costs, rising literacy rates, and the emergence of commercial lending libraries. The press, in Dubois's account, was a necessary but insufficient condition for widespread access to information. Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

A: Dubois has uncovered evidence that the printing press was developed significantly earlier than the fifteenth century, requiring historians to revise the accepted timeline of European intellectual history.

B: Dubois argues that the democratization of knowledge in Europe depended not on the printing press alone but equally on broader economic and social developments that unfolded over two centuries.

C: Dubois contends that the printing press had negligible impact on European society because early printed books were too expensive for anyone outside the wealthiest institutions to purchase.

D: Dubois's research focuses primarily on the role that commercial lending libraries played in sixteenth-century France, treating the printing press as largely irrelevant to the spread of knowledge.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Trick: Locate the 'necessary but insufficient' structure. Dubois says the press was needed -- but not enough on its own. A invents a revised timeline for the press, C overstates to 'negligible impact' (Dubois calls it 'necessary'), and D narrows to lending libraries in France (just one of several factors listed, and the passage does not specify France).

END QUESTION

QUESTION 23**SECTION: READING_WRITING****CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Idea****DIFFICULTY: HARD**

PROMPT: Linguistic anthropologist Mei-Ling Zhou studies code-switching -- the practice of alternating between two or more languages within a single conversation. While earlier scholars characterized code-switching as a sign of linguistic deficiency, Zhou's fieldwork among bilingual communities in Southeast Asia reveals that speakers deploy code-switches strategically to signal group identity, mark changes in topic, or convey shades of meaning unavailable in either language alone. Zhou concludes that code-switching is not a breakdown of linguistic competence but rather an expression of it. Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

A: Zhou's fieldwork confirms the conclusions of earlier scholars who identified code-switching as evidence that bilingual speakers have not fully mastered either of their languages.

B: Zhou has demonstrated that bilingual speakers in Southeast Asia consistently prefer one language over the other in most social settings, reserving the secondary language for private conversations.

C: Zhou's research focuses primarily on documenting and preserving endangered languages in Southeast Asia by studying how bilingual speakers transition between dominant and minority languages.

D: Zhou's research demonstrates that code-switching is a deliberate, skilled communicative strategy rather than a sign of incomplete language mastery, overturning earlier scholarly assumptions.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Trick: Identify the reversal claim. Zhou's conclusion directly flips the old view: code-switching is 'not a breakdown of competence but rather an expression of it.' A sides with the old view (which Zhou refutes), B invents a language preference claim (not discussed), and C shifts the topic to language preservation (Zhou studies communicative strategy, not endangerment).

END QUESTION

QUESTION 24**SECTION: READING_WRITING****CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Idea****DIFFICULTY: HARD**

PROMPT: Epigenetic modifications -- chemical changes to DNA that affect gene expression without altering the underlying sequence -- were long thought to be erased completely between generations. Geneticist Samuel Osei has presented evidence challenging this view: in experiments with laboratory mice, offspring whose parents were exposed to specific environmental stressors displayed altered stress-hormone levels even though the offspring themselves were raised in neutral conditions. Osei acknowledges that extrapolating these findings to humans requires caution, since the controlled conditions of laboratory research cannot replicate the complexity of human environments. Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A: Osei's mouse experiments suggest that some epigenetic changes may pass between generations, though he emphasizes the need for caution when applying animal findings to human populations.
- B: Osei has definitively proven that stress experienced by parents is genetically transmitted to their offspring in both mice and humans, confirming that epigenetic modifications persist across generations without exception.
- C: Osei's research shows that epigenetic modifications function by permanently altering the underlying DNA sequence, which is the mechanism through which environmental effects are inherited across generations.
- D: Osei's work has been widely criticized because the controlled conditions of his laboratory experiments make his findings inapplicable to any organism outside of laboratory-bred mice.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Trick: Find the scope limitation. Results come from mice, and Osei 'acknowledges that extrapolating to humans requires caution.' The correct answer includes both the finding (inheritance in mice) and the caveat (caution about humans). B claims proof in humans (overstates), C says epigenetics alters the DNA sequence (contradicts 'without altering the underlying sequence'), and D says findings are inapplicable (Osei urges caution, not dismissal).

END QUESTION

QUESTION 25**SECTION: READING_WRITING****CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Idea****DIFFICULTY: HARD**

PROMPT: The following text is from Ingrid Solheim's 2017 novel *Northern Meridian*. The lighthouse keeper recorded the weather not because anyone asked her to -- the station had been automated years ago -- but because the ritual of observation steadied her. Wind speed, cloud type, barometric pressure: each measurement was a sentence in a language that did not require interpretation. People's words, by contrast, always seemed to carry a second meaning she could not parse. The logbook, at least, said exactly what it meant. Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A: The lighthouse keeper resents the automation of her station and continues performing her former duties as an act of professional defiance against the decision to replace her.
- B: The lighthouse keeper's weather observations serve as an unofficial scientific record that supplements the automated data collected by the station's monitoring equipment.
- C: The lighthouse keeper continues recording weather data because the precision of measurement offers her a clarity and steadiness that she cannot find in the ambiguity of human communication.
- D: The lighthouse keeper uses her weather logbook as a disguised personal journal in which she records private thoughts alongside meteorological data.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Trick: Identify the central contrast. Weather data = 'a language that did not require interpretation.' People's words = 'a second meaning she could not parse.' The correct answer must capture this opposition between measurement's clarity and language's ambiguity. A invents resentment and defiance (not stated), B focuses on scientific utility (the passage is about personal comfort), and D fabricates a journal element.

END QUESTION